

Chapter 38 - Can't Escape

Around two o'clock in the afternoon, Feng Yue started working in the kitchen on her last filming session before Golden Week.

This time she was making small snacks to bring for Wen Zhen and Zhou Qiongqiong during their Golden Week trip: salted egg yolk cookies, egg yolk pastries, and the fruit tea that Zhou Qiongqiong had mentioned liking last time.

However, today was just filming once. She would make the ones to bring on the trip the day before they left.

So what she made today would be taken back to her parents to taste.

Actually, she wasn't very good at making these small snacks. Even after watching online tutorials and failing several times during practice before filming.

However, she did have some talent. After making them two more times, although the appearance wasn't great, the taste was good.

For making these two snacks, the most important ingredient was salted egg yolk, which she had also cured in advance. After cracking the duck eggs, only the yolks were solid while the whites remained liquid.

Feng Yue processed the ingredients quickly. Before long, twenty salted egg yolks were neatly arranged, sprayed with a bit of white wine, and sent into the oven.

Then she began making the pastry shell for the egg yolk pastries, mixing flour with butter and water, kneading it, then letting the dough rest for thirty minutes in the refrigerator to relax.

During this waiting time, she took out fully cured salted duck eggs to extract the yolks, then melted butter in a pan and poured the salted egg yolks in to stir-fry, then added some milk powder, and finally poured in the prepared marshmallows.

Once all the ingredients in the pan were fully combined, Feng Yue took out small cookies and sandwiched the filling from the pan between two cookies, setting them aside to wait for the filling to cool.

Feng Yue's movements were clean and efficient. By the time she finished with the cookies, the egg yolk pastries were about ready too. She took the salted egg yolks out of the oven and wrapped them individually in the divided, rested, and rolled dough, arranging them one by one on a baking tray, then sprinkling some black sesame seeds on top before sending them into the oven.

The fruit tea was ready-made in her refrigerator, so she didn't need to make it, but because she wanted to show it in the video, she still took out her cup, poured herself a glass, and included it in the video for display.

When the egg yolk pastries came out of the oven, she took a group photo of them along with the small cookies and the poured fruit tea with her camera.

After finishing the final display shots, Feng Yue turned off the camera, then arranged the finished items neatly, packaging them all up to take back to her parents later.

Feng Yue enjoyed cooking in the kitchen but really disliked cleaning it up, so every time she happily finished cooking, she would glumly clean the kitchen afterward.

Whenever she started cleaning the kitchen, she would think about whether she should hire someone to help her clean. Of course, in the end, her territorial instincts would win out—she really didn't like others invading her private space.

After cleaning the kitchen and importing the video footage from her camera into her computer, Feng Yue finally picked up the packaged snacks and her computer and left home.

When Feng Yue drove back home, it was around six o'clock. She had already called her mother to say she was coming back for dinner, so the housekeeper wasn't surprised to see her.

"Nuannuan, you're back! Come in quickly for dinner. Your mother and the others are all waiting for you." The housekeeper smiled warmly as she welcomed Feng Yue into the house. Like Feng Yue's mother, she had been calling Feng Yue by her nickname since childhood.

"Auntie Zhao, these are some small snacks I made myself. I packed some for you too. Please try them." The Feng family's housekeeper, Auntie Zhao, had practically watched Feng Yue grow up. So as soon as she got out of the car, she handed a packaged bag of snacks to her.

Auntie Zhao didn't decline, just smiled and accepted them, then took Feng Yue's coat: "Thank you, Nuannuan. Go in quickly, everyone's waiting for you."

Feng Yue nodded, and as soon as she walked out of the entrance hall, she saw a room full of people sitting in the living room. When they saw her, they all began greeting her enthusiastically.

"Oh my, Xiao Yue is back! Come sit down quickly."

"It's really been so long since we've seen each other. Xiao Yue gets more beautiful every time."

"Yes, walking down the street, even this little aunt would almost not recognize her."

Feng Yue could barely handle their enthusiasm and quickly greeted them: "Second Aunt, Third Aunt, Little Aunt." Only then did she turn her gaze to Mother Feng.

She saw Mother Feng wearing a soulless smile.

Feng Yue: ...

Along with her three aunts came their children: Second Aunt's daughter, Third Aunt's son, and Little Aunt didn't have children yet.

The two kids weren't much younger than Feng Yue, both around 20 years old.

They weren't particularly close to Feng Yue, but they were polite and still called her "Sister."

Father Feng had work at the company today and wouldn't be home for dinner, so the dinner table was filled with women, except for Third Aunt's son.

Conversation was unavoidable at the dinner table, and Feng Yue's three aunts were experts at small talk.

"Xiao Yue, I heard from your mother that you're filming videos online now? What kind are they? Ballet? I remember you studied ballet for a while when you were little." Little Aunt was the youngest among the elders and understood online things better.

Feng Yue hadn't spent much time with these elders—she had previously spent more time with Yan Lin.

"No, I film cooking videos, food content. I just started recently and haven't posted many yet."

Second Aunt was somewhat surprised: "These days, even cooking can be filmed and posted online?"

"Absolutely, those people who post videos are called bloggers or something, basically they're internet celebrities making money." Third Aunt said.

Second Aunt clearly didn't like the term "internet celebrity." Hearing this, she frowned: "Xiao Yue, it's not that Second Aunt is criticizing you, but you're a top student from the finance department. Why are you doing internet celebrity work now? What a waste."

Mother Feng was unhappy hearing this: "You can't say that. As long as it's something she wants to do, it's not a waste. Besides, there's no rule that studying finance means you have to work in finance, right?"

Second Aunt was silenced and looked a bit stiff. She stopped talking and turned to her daughter: "You've never been as capable as your Sister Xiao Yue. She can go film videos, but don't you dare do such things. Study hard, graduate, and then work at your uncle's company."

The girl mumbled an acknowledgment without saying more.

Fortunately, the three aunts timely changed the topic, and the rest of the meal went relatively smoothly.

However, when everyone had almost finished eating, Mother Feng looked toward Third Aunt, signaling her to talk about the real business.

Third Aunt nodded, then looked at Feng Yue: "Xiao Yue, we know you and Xiao Yan are divorced, right?"

Feng Yue nodded, feeling an ominous premonition.

Sure enough, the next second she heard Third Aunt say: "I have a young man here, about your age, the son of your uncle's colleague. He just returned from studying abroad, tall and handsome. Would you like to meet him?"

Although same-sex marriage had been legal for several years, when setting up blind dates for younger family members, people subconsciously still chose the opposite sex, especially someone like Third Aunt.

Feng Yue looked at Third Aunt somewhat helplessly and stated: "Third Aunt, I like women. I'm not heterosexual."

"What heterosexual or homosexual? You've never been with anyone other than Xiao Yan. How can you decide you don't like men?"

What kind of logic was this? Did Third Aunt think her sexual orientation was a kaleidoscope that could change at will?

Feng Yue was somewhat speechless, just smiled awkwardly and refused: "Third Aunt, I really don't have that mindset now, and I think living alone is quite good."

"Don't rush to refuse. Look at the photo first." Third Aunt nudged her son sitting next to her who was focused on eating: "Quick, show your sister the photo your dad sent."

The young man helplessly took out his phone from his bag, then opened the photo and handed it to Feng Yue: "Sister, take a look."

Feng Yue glanced at it. It was indeed as Third Aunt described—tall and thin—but for Feng Yue, looking at men was like looking at strangers on the street; it didn't interest her at all.

Feng Yue turned to look at Mother Feng, hoping she would come to her rescue.

Seeing this, Mother Feng could only sigh and give Third Aunt a meaningful look.

Feng Yue really wasn't interested, and they couldn't force her to go on a blind date.

"I actually have a suitable candidate here." Little Aunt, who hadn't spoken, raised her head: "A girl, 28 years old, who opened a law firm in Beijing."

Feng Yue: ...

How was this still going on endlessly?

"Nuannuan, would you like to meet her? Even if nothing comes of it, you can still make a friend. How about it?" Mother Feng looked at Feng Yue with some expectation.

Feng Yue looked at her mother and silently sighed. Her mother had indeed discussed this issue with her before. She had directly refused then, saying she probably didn't have plans to date for the time being.

Her mother hadn't said anything at the time, and she thought the matter was settled. She didn't expect it to be waiting for her here.

"Even if the blind date doesn't work out, it's still making a friend, don't you think?" After Mother Feng finished speaking, the several aunts began persuading her in various ways.

The other two children at the dinner table were almost covering their ears and burying their heads in their bowls.

And Mother Feng had already said this much—Feng Yue really couldn't bring herself to refuse.

"Alright, let's meet then. But whether it works out in the end, you can't force it."

Feng Yue gave in, and their purpose for today's meal was achieved.

When seeing off the three aunts, Feng Yue also received pitying looks from the two children.

Feng Yue: ...

Around nine in the evening, just as Feng Yue was preparing to lie down and rest, her bedroom door was knocked.

It was Mother Feng.

"Mom, what's the matter this late?"

"Mom was afraid you might resent me, so I came to apologize."

Feng Yue laughed: "It's not that serious. I know you mean well. I don't blame you."

Mother Feng pulled her to sit on the bedside and patted her shoulder: "I'm glad you don't blame mom. Actually, I only invited Third Aunt today, but somehow Second Aunt got wind of it and brought her daughter along, and then Little Aunt came too."

"Second Aunt probably came for her daughter's future job, right? Little Aunt... maybe she was just bored and wanted to watch the excitement?" Feng Yue recalled carefully and said.

"You child, how improper! Your Little Aunt came to watch your excitement for no reason?" Mother Feng looked at her with mock reproach, though her words carried a hint of smile. "But it's good that Little Aunt came too, otherwise there really wouldn't be any suitable blind date candidates."

"Sigh, it's also my fault for not thinking of it at the moment and subconsciously having Third Aunt suggest a boy."

"It's fine. Just don't let her make introductions in the future." Feng Yue smiled.

"Got it, got it. I'll ask Little Aunt—she's reliable."

Feng Yue: ... Alright then.

"But Mom still needs to explain this to you properly." Mother Feng took Feng Yue's hand: "Mom doesn't want to force you to get married or anything. Our family could support twenty more of you without any problem. But Nuannuan, Mom is afraid you won't have anyone to take care of you in the future."

"Your father and I will inevitably leave before you do. After we're gone, you'll be alone, and you're currently ill too. We don't necessarily want you to get married, but you need to have more friends. When Mom said to treat it as making friends, that wasn't just to appease you."

"As long as you have enough friends or other relatives who care about you, then your father and I can leave with peace of mind in the future."

"Mom hopes you'll be well, hopes someone will take good care of you, regardless of whether that person is your partner or something else."